

USER MANUAL

Automated Requesting System

Complete Guide to Roles, Features, and Workflows (ARS)

A paperless request-and-multi-level-approval platform for HR, administrative, and finance paperwork — covering every user role, every form, and every feature of the system.

Document version 1.0 • Prepared for internal use • Covers: Forms & Approvals, Employee/Department/Company Management, Notifications, Internal Chat, Tools Suite, Settings

Table of Contents

1.	Introduction & Purpose
2.	System Overview
2.1	Technology Stack
2.2	Logging In & Getting Started
2.3	The Dashboard
3.	User Roles & Permissions
3.1	Role Map
3.2	Shared Queues & Delegation
4.	The Forms Module
4.1	The Seven Request Forms
4.2	Submitting a Request (All Staff)
4.3	Tracking a Submission
4.4	Editing, Withdrawing & Deleting
5.	The Approval Workflow
5.1	Administrative Forms Pipeline
5.2	Finance Forms Pipeline
5.3	Reimbursement & Liquidation Pipeline
5.4	Approving or Rejecting a Request
6.	Role-by-Role Instructions
6.1	Regular Employee (Staff)
6.2	Immediate Head / Supervisor
6.3	Department Head / Master Approver
6.4	Accounting / Process Approver
6.5	HR Verifier
6.6	Finance Head / Evaluation Approver
6.7	Management / Final Approver
6.8	Procurement / Admin Approver
6.9	System Administrator (IT)
7.	Notifications
8.	Internal Chat
9.	Tools Suite
10.	Administration: Employees, Departments & Companies
11.	Settings
12.	Profile & Account
13.	Troubleshooting & FAQ
14.	Appendix: Reference Tables

1. Introduction & Purpose

The **Automated Requesting System (ARS)** replaces paper-based office forms with a single web application. Employees file requests online; each request is automatically routed through the correct chain of reviewers and approvers based on its type; and everyone involved can see exactly where a request stands at any time.

ARS is built for small and medium enterprises that want to:

- Eliminate paper forms and manual routing for HR/admin/finance requests.
- Enforce a consistent, auditable, multi-level approval chain for every request type.
- Give employees real-time visibility into the status of their own requests.
- Give approvers a single inbox of everything currently waiting on them.
- Keep a searchable record of every request, decision, and remark.

This manual documents every role in the system and every feature available to it — the seven request forms, the multi-level approval engine, the internal chat, the built-in office tools, and the administrative screens used to manage employees, departments, and companies.

2. System Overview

2.1 Technology Stack

Layer	Technology
Server language	PHP (custom lightweight MVC — no external framework)
Database	MySQL / MariaDB
Front end	Server-rendered PHP views, Bootstrap 5, vanilla JavaScript
Email / notifications	PHPMailer
Configuration	vlucas/phpdotenv (<code>.env</code> file)
Dependency manager	Composer
Deployment	Apache/XAMPP for local use, or Docker + docker-compose

2.2 Logging In & Getting Started

1. Obtain your account **username/email** and **password** from your IT Administrator (SysAdmin). Accounts are not self-registered — the SysAdmin creates every account.
 2. Connect to the correct company network (Wi-Fi/LAN) if the system is hosted on a local server, or open the public URL if it is hosted online.
 3. Open the login page in your browser and enter your credentials.
 4. If your browser shows a certificate warning on a locally-hosted, company-network instance, this is expected on a self-signed certificate — proceed only if you recognize the network as your company's.
 5. On first login, go to your **Profile** page and confirm your details; you may also set a profile photo.
 6. Forgot your password? Use the **Forgot Password** link on the login page to receive a reset link by email.

Note: This is a role-gated system — what you see after logging in (menu items, buttons, and pages) depends entirely on the role your SysAdmin assigned to your account.

2.3 The Dashboard

After logging in you land on the **Dashboard** — your home screen. From here, the sidebar gives access to every module you have permission to use: Forms, Approvals, My Submissions, All Requests (SysAdmin only), Notifications, Chat, Tools, Employees/Departments/Companies (SysAdmin only), Settings, and your Profile.

3. User Roles & Permissions

Every employee account has exactly one role, stored as a **role_id**. The role determines the menus, pages, and actions available to that account.

3.1 Role Map

ID	Role Name	Core Responsibility
1	SysAdmin (IT)	Full system access; manages accounts, departments, companies, and settings; can act at any approval stage; completes Finance forms after final approval.
2	Immediate Head / Supervisor	First-level checker on all forms submitted by their direct reports.
3	Regular Employee (Staff)	Files requests; views only their own submissions.
4	Department Head / Master Approver	Evaluation approver on Administrative forms; can also stand in as Checker on any form type.
5	Accounting / Process Approver	Process-stage approver on Finance forms; co-signs Reimbursement/Liquidation with HR.
6	Management / Final Approver	Final approval authority on every form type (shared queue).
7	Procurement / Admin Approver	Stands in for other stages depending on form type (see 3.2).
8	Finance Head / Evaluation Approver	Evaluation-stage approver on Finance forms (shared queue).
9	HR Verifier	Co-signs the Process stage on Reimbursement/Liquidation, cross-checking attendance (shared queue).

3.2 Shared Queues & Delegation

Several roles are **not tied to one specific person** — any account holding that role can see and act on the relevant pending requests, and whoever acts first completes the stage:

- **Final Approver (role 6)** — every Final Approver sees every pending Final Approval request, on every form type.
- **Finance Head (role 8)** — every Finance Head sees every pending Evaluation Approval request.
- **HR Verifier (role 9)** — every HR Verifier sees every pending HR co-sign request (Reimbursement/Liquidation only).
- **Master Approver (role 4)** — in addition to the normal Dept. Head stage on Admin forms, can also act as Checker on any form type.
- **Admin Approver (role 7)** — stands in for: *Vehicle Request* (Checker, Dept. Head, Final); *Leave Application & Overtime* (Dept. Head only). Never the default assignee, only a stand-in.

Once a Final Approver, HR Verifier, or Finance Head acts on a request — even one not personally assigned to them — they retain the ability to view it afterward, including in Approval History.

Tip: An employee can also be given a specific Master Approver, HR Verifier, or Finance Head individually (set on their employee record). That specific person is tried first; the system only falls back to the shared queue if no specific person is assigned.

4. The Forms Module

4.1 The Seven Request Forms

Advance Payment Form

Requests an advance/cash payment ahead of an anticipated expense.

- Applicant, Department
- Pages (attachment count), Date
- Project Name, Project No.
- Type of Payment
- Payee, Account Name
- Bank Name, Bank Account No.
- Address
- Purpose
- Total Amount
- Total Amount (in words)

Overtime Authorization Form

Requests authorization for overtime work.

- Employee Name
- Department
- Date
- Total Hours Rendered

Request for Payment Form

Submits a payment request for services, purchases, or obligations.

- Applicant, Department
- Pages, Date
- Project Name, Project No.
- Type of Payment
- Payee, Account Name
- Bank Name, Bank Account No.
- Address
- Purpose
- Total Amount
- Total Amount (in words)

Leave Application Form

Applies for leave and tracks the employee's leave-credit balance.

- Name, Department
- ID No.
- Date Filed
- From / To dates
- Number of Leave Days
- Type of Leave
- In case of Vacation (details)
- In case of Sick (details)
- Payment Term

Reimbursement Form

Claims repayment for a business expense already paid by the employee.

- Name, Department
- Pages, Date
- Total Amount
- Total Amount (in words)

Liquidation Form

Reconciles actual expenses against a previously issued cash advance.

- Name, Department
- Pages, Date
- Advance Date, Advance Type
- Advance Amount
- Total Amount
- Balance / Refund

- Total Amount (in words)

Vehicle Request Form

Requests a company vehicle for official use.

- Car / Plate Number
- Date
- Applicant, Department
- Total Mileage
- Schedule Time
- Type of Trip
- Destination
- Purpose
- Notes

4.2 Submitting a Request (All Staff)

1. From the sidebar, open **Forms** and choose the form type you need.
2. Fill in the required fields. Your name/department are usually pre-filled from your profile.
3. Attach any supporting documents where the form allows an attachment.
4. Review the entry, then click **Submit**. The request is created with status `Draft → Submitted` and is immediately routed to your Immediate Head for the Checker stage.
5. You'll receive a notification whenever the request moves to the next stage, is approved, is rejected, or is completed.

4.3 Tracking a Submission

Open **My Submissions** to see every request you have filed, its current status, and its position in the pipeline. Click a request to open its detail page, which shows the full **Approval Trail** — every stage, who acted, when, and any remarks left.

4.4 Editing, Withdrawing & Deleting

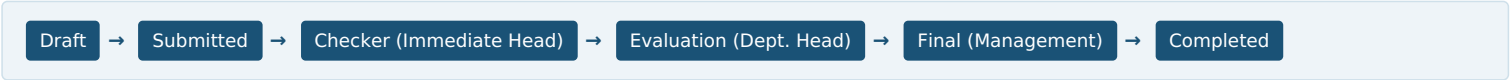
A request can be edited or deleted by its submitter (or the SysAdmin) while it is still early in the pipeline; once later-stage approvers have acted, editing is restricted to preserve the audit trail. Rejected requests show the rejection remark so the employee can correct and resubmit if the process allows it.

5. The Approval Workflow

Every form type follows one of three fixed pipelines, based on its category. At each stage, the assigned approver (or anyone in that role's shared queue) can **Approve** (advance the request) or **Reject** (send it back to the requester with a required remark).

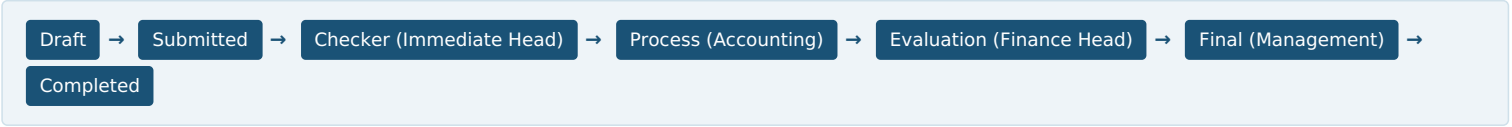
5.1 Administrative Forms Pipeline

Applies to: **Overtime Authorization, Leave Application, Vehicle Request**



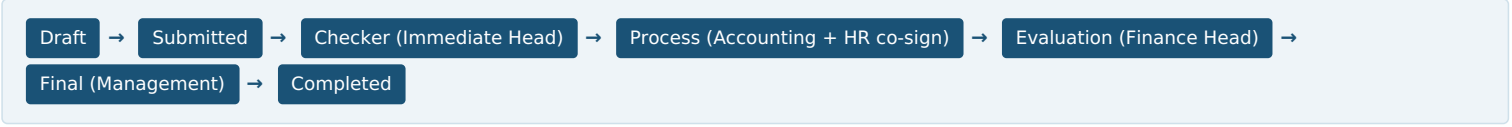
5.2 Finance Forms Pipeline

Applies to: **Advance Payment, Request for Payment**



5.3 Reimbursement & Liquidation Pipeline

Same as the Finance pipeline, except the **Process** stage requires two co-signers:



Note: At the Process stage on Reimbursement and Liquidation, **both HR and Accounting** must sign off before the request advances to Evaluation. Advance Payment and Request for Payment go through Accounting alone at that stage.

5.4 Approving or Rejecting a Request

1. Open **Approvals** from the sidebar — this is your personal inbox of everything currently waiting on your role.
2. Click a request to review its full details and any attachments.
3. Check the **Approval Trail** to see what earlier approvers already confirmed.
4. Click **Approve** to move the request to the next stage, or **Reject** and enter a remark explaining why.
5. The requester and the next approver in line are notified automatically.

Tip: If you hold a shared-queue role (Final Approver, Finance Head, or HR Verifier), a request may already have been acted on by a colleague with the same role by the time you open it — that's expected behavior, not an error.

6. Role-by-Role Instructions

This section walks through exactly what each role sees and does in ARS, day to day.

Role 3 6.1 Regular Employee (Staff)

Can do: File any of the 7 request forms; track only their own submissions; use Chat and Tools; edit their profile.

Cannot do: View or act on anyone else's requests; access Employees, Departments, Companies, or admin Settings.

Typical flow: Forms → choose form type → fill in and submit → track progress under My Submissions → respond to a rejection remark by editing and resubmitting if allowed.

Role 2 6.2 Immediate Head / Supervisor

Can do: Everything a Staff account can, *plus* the Checker stage — the first review — on every request submitted by their direct reports, across all 7 form types.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → open a pending request from a direct report → review → Approve (sends it on to the Evaluation/Process stage) or Reject (returns it to the employee with a remark).

Role 4 6.3 Department Head / Master Approver

Can do: Handles the **Evaluation (Dept. Head)** stage on Administrative forms (Overtime, Leave, Vehicle Request). Can also stand in as **Checker** on *any* form type if needed.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → Administrative-form requests that have cleared the Checker stage appear here → Approve to send to Final (Management), or Reject back to the employee.

Role 5 6.4 Accounting / Process Approver

Can do: Handles the **Process (Accounting Checking)** stage on all Finance forms (Advance Payment, Request for Payment, Reimbursement, Liquidation). On Reimbursement/Liquidation, co-signs alongside HR — and can also stand in for HR's row at that stage.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → review Finance requests that cleared the Checker stage → verify figures/attachments → Approve (moves to Evaluation once all required co-signers have signed) or Reject.

Role 9 6.5 HR Verifier

Can do: Co-signs the Process stage specifically on **Reimbursement** and **Liquidation** forms, cross-checking the request against attendance records. Shared queue — any HR Verifier account can act, and whoever acts first is recorded.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → open a pending Reimbursement/Liquidation → cross-check attendance → Approve (the request waits for Accounting's co-sign, or advances once both have signed) or Reject.

Role 8 6.6 Finance Head / Evaluation Approver

Can do: Handles the **Evaluation (Finance Head Checking)** stage on all Finance forms, after Accounting/HR sign-off. Shared queue.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → review Finance requests that cleared Process → Approve to send to Final (Management), or Reject.

Role 6 6.7 Management / Final Approver

Can do: Grants **Final Approval** on every form type — Administrative and Finance alike. This is the last approval authority before a request is marked Completed. Shared queue.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → review any request that has cleared all earlier stages → Approve to finalize, or Reject. Administrative forms complete immediately on Final Approval; Finance forms are then marked Completed by the SysAdmin once payment/processing is done.

Role 7 6.8 Procurement / Admin Approver

Can do: A flexible stand-in role, not a default assignee. Coverage depends on form type:

- **Vehicle Request** — can stand in as Checker, Dept. Head (Evaluation), or Final Approver.
- **Leave Application & Overtime Authorization** — can stand in as Dept. Head (Evaluation) only.

Typical flow: Approvals inbox → any pending request the Admin Approver is eligible to cover appears here alongside the primary approver's queue.

Role 1 6.9 System Administrator (IT / SysAdmin)

Can do: Full access to the system.

- Act on behalf of *any* approval stage on any form.
- Marks Finance requests **Completed** once Final Approval has been granted and payment/processing is done.
- Manages **Employees** — create, edit, deactivate accounts; assign role, department, company, and specific Master Approver / HR Verifier / Finance Head per employee.
- Manages **Departments** and **Companies**, including each company's logo/branding.
- Views **All Requests** system-wide and exports completed requests to CSV.
- Configures system-wide **Settings**: general app settings, mail (SMTP), storage, and default notification behavior.

Typical flow: Employees → create/edit accounts and set roles → Departments/Companies → maintain org structure → Requests (All Requests) → oversee every request in the system → Settings → configure mail and storage.

7. Notifications

The bell icon in the top bar shows unread notifications for your account. ARS notifies you when:

- A request you submitted changes status (approved, rejected, or completed).
- A new request is waiting for your action at your approval stage.
- You receive a new chat message.

1. Click the bell icon to see your unread notifications.
 2. Click a notification to jump directly to the related request or chat.
 3. Use **Mark all as read** to clear the unread badge.

8. Internal Chat

ARS includes a built-in messaging tool so employees can coordinate without leaving the system.

Features

- **Direct messaging** between any two employees.
- **File & image sharing** — attach files directly in a conversation.
- **Share a form** — send a link to a specific request straight into a chat (access to the shared form still follows normal permissions: admin, submitter, or an assigned approver).
- **Reactions** on messages.
- **Typing indicators** and **read receipts** (mark-as-read, unread counts).
- **Live updates** via polling, so new messages appear without refreshing the page.
- **Block / unblock** a user to stop receiving messages from them.
- **Delete** your own sent messages.

1. Open **Chat** from the sidebar.
2. Select a colleague from the user list to open (or start) a conversation.
3. Type a message, attach a file, or use the share-form option, then send.
4. Use the block option from a conversation's menu if you need to stop messages from a specific user; unblock the same way.

9. Tools Suite

The **Tools** page bundles a few everyday utilities into one place:

Tool	What it does
World Clock	View the current time across multiple time zones.
Calculator	A basic on-screen calculator.
Height & Weight Converter	Convert between metric and imperial units.
Notes	Personal sticky notes — create, edit, color-code, and delete notes tied to your account only.
Leave Credits	A summary of your leave allotment, leave used, and leave remaining, calculated from your completed Leave Application forms.
Payslip Request	A quick shortcut under "Services" to notify HR that you'd like a payslip for a given period.

Note: Notes are private to your account — no one else, including the SysAdmin, sees your personal notes through this feature.

10. Administration: Employees, Departments & Companies

These screens are restricted to the **SysAdmin (role 1)** only.

10.1 Employee Management

1. Open **Employees** from the sidebar to see every account in the system.
 2. Click **Add Employee** to create a new account — set their name, login credentials, department, company, and role.
 3. Optionally assign a **specific** Master Approver, HR Verifier, or Finance Head for that individual employee (used before falling back to the shared queue for that role).
 4. Click an existing employee to **Edit** their details, change their role, or reassign their approvers.
 5. Use **Deactivate/Activate** to disable or re-enable an account's login access without deleting their history.
 6. Use **Delete** to permanently remove an account (use with care — this affects historical records tied to that user).

10.2 Department Management

Open **Departments** to add, rename, or remove departments, and to view each department's member list.

10.3 Company Management

Open **Companies** to add, rename, or remove companies/branches (for multi-entity setups), view each company's members, and upload/replace a company logo used in headers and printed/exported documents.

11. Settings

The Settings page is visible to everyone, but tabs are shown or hidden based on role.

Tab	Who can change it	What it controls
General	SysAdmin only	Core application settings (e.g. company name/branding defaults).
Mail	SysAdmin only	SMTP / outgoing email configuration used for notifications and password resets.
Storage	SysAdmin only	File storage configuration for uploads and attachments.
Appearance	Every user	Personal theme/display preference.
Notifications	Every user	Personal notification preferences.

Per-user settings (Appearance, Notifications) override the global defaults set by the SysAdmin, but only for that individual's own account.

12. Profile & Account

1. Open **Profile** from the sidebar or top-right menu.
2. Review your account details (name, department, company, role).
3. Click your avatar to upload or replace your profile photo.
4. Use the password change / forgot-password flow if you need to update your login credentials.

13. Troubleshooting & FAQ

I can't log in.

Confirm you're on the correct network (for LAN-hosted instances) and using the exact credentials issued by your SysAdmin. Use **Forgot Password** if you're unsure of your password, or contact your SysAdmin to confirm your account is active.

I submitted a request but don't see it move forward.

Open the request's Approval Trail (via My Submissions) to see exactly which stage it's waiting at and who is responsible for acting next. Requests only advance once the assigned approver (or someone in that role's shared queue) takes action.

I'm an approver but don't see a request I was told about.

Check that the request has actually reached your stage — earlier stages must clear first. If you hold a shared-queue role, it's also possible a colleague with the same role already acted on it; check the Approval Trail on that request.

My request was rejected — what now?

Open the request to read the rejection remark, then correct the issue and resubmit if the workflow allows editing at that stage; otherwise, file a new request.

Why can't I see Employees, Departments, or Companies in my sidebar?

These screens are restricted to the SysAdmin role. If you believe you should have administrative access, contact your SysAdmin.

A 403 "Access Denied" page appeared.

You tried to open a page that your current role isn't permitted to access. This is expected behavior, not a bug — return to the Dashboard and use only the menu items visible to you.

14. Appendix: Reference Tables

14.1 Full Role Reference

ID	Role	Stage(s) Owned	Notes
1	SysAdmin (IT)	Any stage (override)	Also completes Finance forms; full admin access.
2	Immediate Head	Checker — all form types	Reviews direct reports' submissions.
3	Regular Employee	Submitter	Own submissions only.
4	Master Approver / Dept. Head	Evaluation — Admin forms; Checker stand-in — any form	Dual capability.
5	Accounting	Process — Finance forms	Co-signs with HR on Reimbursement/Liquidation; can stand in for HR.
6	Final Approver	Final — all form types	Shared queue.
7	Admin Approver	Stand-in only (see 3.2)	Never a default assignee.
8	Finance Head	Evaluation — Finance forms	Shared queue.
9	HR Verifier	Process co-sign — Reimbursement/Liquidation	Shared queue; cross-checks attendance.

14.2 Form Category Reference

Category	Forms	Pipeline
Administrative	Overtime Authorization, Leave Application, Vehicle Request	Draft → Submitted → Checker → Evaluation (Dept. Head) → Final → Completed
Finance	Advance Payment, Request for Payment	Draft → Submitted → Checker → Process (Accounting) → Evaluation (Finance Head) → Final → Completed
Finance (co-sign)	Reimbursement, Liquidation	Draft → Submitted → Checker → Process (Accounting + HR) → Evaluation (Finance Head) → Final → Completed

14.3 Sample Test Accounts by Stage (Administrative Forms)

Step	Stage	Account
1	Requestor submits	Requestor / Staff account
2	Checker (Immediate Head)	Immediate Supervisor account
3	Evaluation (Dept. Head)	Department Head account
4	Final (Management)	Final Approver account
5	Completion	System Admin account

14.4 Sample Test Accounts by Stage (Finance Forms)

Step	Stage	Account
1	Requestor submits	Requestor / Staff account
2	Checker (Immediate Head)	Immediate Supervisor account
3	Process (Accounting)	Accounting account
3b	Process — HR co-sign (Reimbursement/Liquidation only)	HR Verifier account
4	Evaluation (Finance Head)	Finance Head account
5	Final Approval	Final Approver account
6	Completion	System Admin account